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The Dogon

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In another way the weaver imitates the *Nommo* who, springing from the clavicles of God, forthwith wove together the four elements contained therein and made from them the whole universe. Just as he drew the four elements from the clavicles of God, so the weaver draws his threads—that is, the four elements—from the spindles, the clavicles of the loom.

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In some sort, textiles form seven 'families' comprising twenty-two principal strips corresponding to the categories of the universe. It seems that the total number must, in theory, be equal to the number of signs inscribed in the original seed (see p. 85). For the strip of cloth is itself a sign and connotes a myth, partial or complete—a material or spiritual image. To wear a particular cloth, ² to possess a certain blanket, is therefore to display a symbol which, in practice, corresponds to the physical or moral condition of the wearer, to his social and religious functions and his ordinary activities, which are themselves in harmony with the rhythm of the universe.

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As among the Bambara, there is a 'science of cloths' which is an account of the mechanism of creation. In the Dogon mind this knowledge is identified with its subject and therefore the possession of the complete number of cloths in the form of a blanket represents the ideal form of wealth, the acme of riches. It is possible to exceed this number, but to acquire twice the ideal number of twenty-two kinds of cloth would be excessive. A man in such a case would surpass the god *Amma* and draw down disaster on his people.

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For this reason men are reluctant to display the family heritage of cloths, for this would be to reveal to the common gaze both the supreme expression of wealth and the symbols of cosmic knowledge. These possessions are never shown except at the death of the family head, at a moment when, in theory, the social upheaval would forbid anyone to count the goods or detect hidden motives. To exhibit cloths at a funerary ceremony is evidence that death has 'gathered up'³ the whole universe under the form of the symbols which also constitute wealth.

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The original situation of the ideal couple—twins enclosed in the same egg—is also illustrated in a religious and economic relationship maintained between the Dogon and the Bozo which has existed, it is said, from the earliest times. This institution, which flourishes over a wide area, is  108 known as a 'joking relationship', though the term 'cathartic alliance' has been suggested for it.¹ A Dogon myth relates that when the reorganization of man first began, Dogon and Bozo, represented by the *Nommo* spirits, had in their clavicles eight seeds and eight fishes respectively. 'The most important thing in the world for the *mangu* (ritual partner)' say the natives, 'is the seeds in his clavicles'.² By this means the Bozo are marked out as fishermen and the Dogon as cultivators. When they came down to the newly made world together, they made a pact whereby they became mutually complementary. This solemn act, at once a consecration and a recognition of the contents of their clavicles, took place on the original field in which the iron-worker's anvil was embedded. His hammer was beating out the rhythm of the first operations and, since hammer and anvil participated in the form and nature of the universal system—in this instance regarded as a granary—the pact was bound up with the rhythm of those two symbols. By the oaths which they exchanged the two eponymous ancestors, who were already twins, confirmed their complementary relationship; each, by the words he spoke, penetrated the other, depositing within his partner something of himself. This 'bridgehead' formed by energy proceeding from himself enabled each to act effectively and with impunity on the other, more especially in that essential action which directly or indirectly effects purification, and which seems to be one of the chief aims of the alliance.

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² It may be simply a piece of cloth inset in a garment made of plain strips.

³ This word may bear the meaning 'to receive for the purpose of hoarding or treasuring' as well as 'to sustain the moral burden' of the knowledge represented by the objects.

¹ See G. Dieterlen, 'Les correspondances cosmo-biologiques chez les Soudanais', *Journal de Psychologie normale et pathologique*, juill.-sept. 1950; M. Griaule, 'L'alliance cathartique', *Africa*, xviii. 4, Oct. 1948, pp. 242-8.

² *aduno magu dye wogo dene inne gozen togodige.*

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